that he was not particularly interested in the immediate tactical or strategic aspect of the impending battle.

Prasad also was not fully focused on the impending Bum-la battle. His main concern was that the Chinese column that had been following him would bypass Tawang and make a rush for the bridge over the Tawang Chu. If the Chinese cut the bridge off, the Tawang garrison would be cut off and therefore doomed. In addition, once he reached Tawang he was given to understand by BGS IV Corps in Tezpur that as per the corps' assessment, the Chinese were only expected to launch an attack on Bum-la on the morning of 24 October.

Meanwhile, in New Delhi, the former commander of 7 Brigade, Brigadier D. K. Palit, was now the Director Military Operations and perhaps the only man in Army HQ who had any knowledge of the actual ground conditions in and around Tawang; he was about to play a crucial role.

The speed with which the situation had unravelled on 20 October had dumbfounded almost everybody. The Chief of Army Staff who had backed Bogey Sen's refusal to pull back from the Nam Ka Chu during the crucial meeting at the prime minister's residence on 11 October now had egg all over his face. The IV Corps Commander, Lieutenant General Kaul, remained confined to his sick bed, surrounded on the evening of 22 October by 'Thapar, Menon, Mullik and Sarin who were sitting around his bed in funeral silence'.

When Thorat had expounded the concept of the defensive line, Palit, by his own admission, had taken a stand against its viability on the grounds that a withdrawal from the McMahon Line to Bomdila would be a useless manoeuvre since it would allow the Chinese to take their objective (which was Tawang) and then not bother to actually fight the Indians on the defensive line. At that time, this stance taken by him as the brigade commander of 7 Brigade, had placed Palit firmly in the 'Kaul Camp' that seemed to be on the ascendancy in the power struggle that was going on in Army HQ. As we know, along with Thimayya, Thorat and others who were considered to be of the old school had also departed. Palit's subsequent elevation to the post of Director Military Operations came as a major shock for there were at least two other officers who were considered to be more appropriate for the job. In his own words: 'I had at first been regarded as one of "Bijji's men", in the pejorative sense, and, I suspect, I never totally